

I Love You

In 2000, a digital menace came out of Philippines, it was a self-replicating worm called ILOVEYOU, which eventually caused more than \$10 billion in damage

Top Racer

The virus called Nimda, which is 'admin' spelled backwards, hit the Internet in 2001 and quickly gained the status of the fastest propagating computer virus of that era

Feature

land mines – viruses, malware, adware, spyware and Trojans keep proliferating at an ever-increasing pace. Even with a genuine and fully updated operating system and a valid anti-virus system, you need to be careful about web sites that you visit, or you could be on your way to joining the long list of victims of a cyber-attack. Here is a look at some of the latest threats that are making news these days.

The nemesis of Social Media: shorter URL

When you are on social media outlets like Facebook or Twitter, posting links with shorter, and a rather condensed, URL makes the message look quite cool. This kind of system is a necessity for a site like Twitter, which currently caps messages at 140 characters. But it is also true that web shortening services like <http://goo.gl> can turn out to be notoriously unsafe. At times they can lead a user to an infected web site. A post on Sophos Naked Security says, "Thousands of Twitter users are finding that their accounts have been tweeting out malicious links without their permission, pointing to a fake anti-virus attack. A quick search on the popular micro-blogging network finds many tweets from users containing no message other than a goo.gl shortened link (Google's equivalent to bit.ly or [tinyurl](http://tinyurl.com)), which itself points to a URL ending with 'm28sx.html'."

It is nothing new to have attacks hiding behind tiny URLs, but when such nefarious strategy is applied on a popular outlet like Twitter, it will

definitely end up affecting many more computer users. In this case, there are no easy solutions; after all, it is not possible to block the domain completely, as it is associated with a genuine company, which has nothing to do with the attack. For instance, <http://goo.gl> is associated with Google. The search giant will never allow <http://goo.gl> to be blocked. Anti virus maker, McAfee has come up with its own system for creating a shortened URL and the company advises users to try its service, which is guaranteed to be completely free of malicious attacks. You can access the McAfee system for generating tiny URLs, by pointing the browser at this web site: <http://mcafee.com>.

Threats from Free Wi-Fi hotspots

There are no free meals in this world – this may sound rather cynical, nevertheless, it is true. Even users of free Wi-Fi hotspots are often being milked through packet-sniffing strategies. Recently Google had admitted that its roaming Street View cameras have been doing more than just snap pictures of the neighbourhood; they had also been collecting packets of information sent over private Wi-Fi networks. The problem was later attributed to oversight error. However, it is a fact that packet-sniffing tools are very easily available on the internet. It is possible for any individual or corporate entity to use these tools for spying on the browsing data of users of any Wi-Fi hot spot. The next time you use the Wi-fi network of an airport, shopping mall or restaurant, you might be revealing your vital secrets to an unknown stalker.

When you are using the Wi-Fi network of your home or the workplace, then you have a degree of control. But if you connect your system to the network of an airport, hotel, restaurant or any other entity or individual, then the control passes out of your hand. It becomes really difficult for you to judge just how private the details of your browsing activity are. Through packet-sniffing tools and other means, it is possible for hackers to sniff out any data, including passwords, that get transmitted through a network. According to some security experts, an

Microsoft Security Essentials

If you are using genuine Windows based operating system, then it might make sense for you to go in for the free anti-virus program from Microsoft – Microsoft Security Essentials. This program will provide real-time protection for your home PC against threats such as - viruses, spyware, and other malicious software. Once you have downloaded and installed the system in your computer, it will update itself automatically with latest virus definitions. Some of the latest adware/spyware threats identified by Microsoft Security Essentials are:

Adware:Win32/ClickPotato
Adware:Win32/Hotbar
BrowserModifier:Win32/Zwangi
Rogue:Win32/Winwebsec
BrowserModifier:Win32/BaiduSobar
Adware:Win32/GameVance
Rogue:Win32/FakeSpypro
Adware:Win32/SideTab
Backdoor:Win32/Cycbot.B
Adware:Win32/Gabpath

open Wi-fi network can also be used for installing key-logger software into the unsuspecting user's system. Once such software has been installed the hacker would be able to keep track of every single word that the user has typed. But there are no easy solutions in this case, as you don't have any control over the Wi-Fi network over which the data flows.

In the early days of 2011, it came to light that internet hackers had targeted lawmakers in Missouri, USA, and their staffs. It is believed that hackers took advantage of the free, open wireless network to side-jack the Facebook accounts of the state representatives and post mischievous messages such as, "I love lobbyists! All the free food and stuff you get. This job is awesome!" This suspicion is due to the fact that each victim of hacking had used the open wireless network recently. If they can breach the security of a Facebook account, then they might also be capable of getting hold of valuable information related to your bank account or credit card. We need to exercise care before using an open Wi-Fi network for doing any kind of financial transaction. 

Targeting the smart phone

If you are an avid smart phone or tablet user, then you have reason to be worried. In its threat report released on February 9, 2011, McAfee has declared there has been a steady rise in number of threats to mobile platforms. The most famous mobile threats of the quarter four period of the year 2010 are SymbOS/Zitmo.A and Android/Geinimi. SymbOS/Zitmo. The strategy behind the malwares is also unique. McAfee has identified instances where Trojan has been inserted into legitimate mobile applications and games for the Android platform.